

Recess and Play

Recess is regulation, not a privilege. Withholding it takes movement from the child who just showed you they need it — and who loses it is not random.

Reach for it when recess is about to be withheld for behaviour or for unfinished work.

The Short Version

Recess is regulation. It is how a bodymind resets.

It is not a privilege, not a reward, and not a bargaining chip. Withholding it takes the regulation away from the child who has just shown you they need it. Then the afternoon goes worse, and the worse afternoon is used to justify taking it again.

Recess should never be withheld — not for behaviour, not for unfinished work, not for anything.

Who loses recess is not random. It falls hardest on Black children, on children from low-income families, and on Disabled and Neurodivergent children.

Why This Sheet Exists

A child struggles in the morning. At eleven o'clock someone says: *you can finish that at break.*

It sounds like a natural consequence. It is the opposite of one. The child who could not sit still, could not finish, could not hold it together — that child has just been identified, correctly, as needing to move. And movement is the thing being removed.

Some schools still treat recess as something a child earns by being easy to teach.

Instead of treating recess as an important, in fact crucial, part of a student's day, some schools still act as if recess is a privilege bestowed on well-behaved, compliant students.

— Laura Hanby Hudgens, [Recess Is Not a Privilege](https://www.huffpost.com/entry/recess-is-not-a-privilege_b_8505720) (https://www.huffpost.com/entry/recess-is-not-a-privilege_b_8505720), *HuffPost*, 8 November 2015

They use recess as a bargaining tool and withhold it as a form of punishment.

— Laura Hanby Hudgens, [Recess Is Not a Privilege](https://www.huffpost.com/entry/recess-is-not-a-privilege_b_8505720) (https://www.huffpost.com/entry/recess-is-not-a-privilege_b_8505720)

Recess Is Not a Privilege

Recess is not a privilege.

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Children should not have to earn recess, and they should not miss recess as a punishment.

— Laura Hanby Hudgens, [Recess Is Not a Privilege](https://www.huffpost.com/entry/recess-is-not-a-privilege_b_8505720) (https://www.huffpost.com/entry/recess-is-not-a-privilege_b_8505720)

The professional position is the same, and it is explicit about *both* of the reasons schools usually give:

The AAP believes that recess is a crucial and necessary component of a child's development and, as such, it should not be withheld for punitive or academic reasons.

— Laura Hanby Hudgens, [Recess Is Not a Privilege](https://www.huffpost.com/entry/recess-is-not-a-privilege_b_8505720) (https://www.huffpost.com/entry/recess-is-not-a-privilege_b_8505720), on the American Academy of Pediatrics

Not for behaviour. Not for unfinished work. Those are the two doors it is taken through, and both are closed.

Withholding It Punishes the Child Who Needed It Most

This is the part that makes it counterproductive rather than merely unkind.

In the case of recess, this punishment is less effective because kids need recess in order to decompress, socialize, and get the wiggles out so that they can focus and behave better in class.

— Laura Hanby Hudgens, [Recess Is Not a Privilege](https://www.huffpost.com/entry/recess-is-not-a-privilege_b_8505720) (https://www.huffpost.com/entry/recess-is-not-a-privilege_b_8505720)

Recess is what makes the next hour possible.

For children, this is precisely the role played by recess; research shows that kids return from a session on the playground better able to focus their attention and to engage their executive function faculties. Yet at schools all over the country, recess has been reduced or even eliminated in order to generate more "seat time" spent on academic learning. The notion that time away from concentrated mental work is effectively time wasted is one of several wrongheaded notions we hold regarding breaks — wrongheaded, in this case, because the ability to attend to such work declines steadily over time, and is actually refreshed by a bout of bodily exertion.

— Annie Murphy Paul, *The Extended Mind* (<https://anniemurphypaul.com/books/the-extended-mind/>), quoted in our [Play](https://stimpunks.org/glossary/play/) (<https://stimpunks.org/glossary/play/>) glossary entry

So the loop closes on the child. Remove the reset, get a worse afternoon, cite the worse afternoon as evidence the child cannot be trusted with the reset. The plan produces the behaviour it then measures.

The Research Does Not Support Cutting It

The case for cutting recess is an assumption. Anthony Pellegrini spent years testing it, and reported the result in the opening lines of his paper:

Some devalue recess because they assume it to be a waste of time. There is no theory or empirical evidence to support this point of view. There is, however, abundant and clear evidence that recess has beneficial effects on children's social competence and academic performance.

— Anthony D. Pellegrini, *The Recess Debate: A Disjuncture between Educational Policy and Scientific Research*, *American Journal of Play* (<https://www.journalofplay.org/>) 1, no. 2 (2008), p. 181

And this is the finding that settles the counterproductive question, because it measures the exact thing withholding does — depriving a child of the break:

...in numerous controlled experiments children's attention to school tasks decreased the longer they were deprived of a break and, correspondingly, children were significantly more attentive after recess than before. It is very much like taking a break on a long highway trip.

— Pellegrini, *The Recess Debate*, p. 183

Attention falls the longer the break is withheld, and rises after it is taken. That is the mechanism, measured under controlled conditions, and it runs precisely opposite to the intervention.

The trade schools think they are making — less play, better results — is not the trade the evidence describes:

There is substantial evidence that physical activity can help improve academic achievement, including grades and standardized test scores.

— a Centers for Disease Control and Prevention report, quoted in *TIME* (<https://time.com/4982061/recess-benefits-research-debate/>)

Who Loses Recess Is Not Random

This is where withheld recess stops being only a regulation issue.

The study also found that black students and students from low-income families were more likely to be given no recess or minimal recess.

— *TIME* (<https://time.com/4982061/recess-benefits-research-debate/>), reporting a 2009 study

The pattern holds at district level, in numbers:

In Seattle Public Schools, 51 percent of black elementary students attended a low-recess school last year, compared to 13 percent of white students.

— Ann Dornfeld, White kids usually get the most recess in Seattle. Black kids, the least (www.kuow.org/stories/...), KUOW, 26 August 2019

Most white kindergarteners in the district get at least 45 minutes of recess a day.

— Ann Dornfeld, KUOW

Anne's story pointed out that the schools with the least amount of recess had high concentrations of students of color and low-income students.

— Jesse Hagopian, Recess in Seattle: How We Won the Right to Play (<https://progressive.org/public-schools-advocate/recess-seattle-won-right-play/>), *The Progressive*, 6 October 2015

Access and time for play are children's rights issues. It's also a racial justice issue.

— Play's Power (<https://writing.humanrestorationproject.org/plays-power/>), Human Restoration Project

And it can be won back. Seattle educators made recess a bargaining demand and took it to the brink of a strike:

On Saturday, September 5, the union's negotiating team announced that the school district had backed down and agreed to a minimum of 30 minutes of recess in every elementary school.

— Jesse Hagopian, [Recess in Seattle: How We Won the Right to Play](https://progressive.org/public-schools-advocate/recess-seattle-won-right-play/) (<https://progressive.org/public-schools-advocate/recess-seattle-won-right-play/>)

Play Is Learning, Not a Break From It

The framing that makes recess cuttable is the idea that play is what happens when learning stops.

Play is not a reward or break from doing learning, play IS learning.

— Abe Moore, [A Playground Should Have A Pulse](https://www.humanrestorationproject.org/writing/a-playground-should-have-a-pulse/) (<https://www.humanrestorationproject.org/writing/a-playground-should-have-a-pulse/>), Human Restoration Project

Recess is NOT a bargaining tool.

— Abe Moore, [A Playground Should Have A Pulse](https://www.humanrestorationproject.org/writing/a-playground-should-have-a-pulse/) (<https://www.humanrestorationproject.org/writing/a-playground-should-have-a-pulse/>)

There is nothing more human than play.

— [Play's Power](https://writing.humanrestorationproject.org/plays-power/) (<https://writing.humanrestorationproject.org/plays-power/>), Human Restoration Project

Taking play away is not a neutral act of scheduling. It is a choice about what a childhood is for.

Oftentimes, this time is taken from them: either punitively through removing recess or other disciplinary action, or as a form of control through "engagement", such as attempting to pair academics and play. We need to give students the opportunity to do things on their own.

— [Human Restoration Project Primer](https://www.humanrestorationproject.org/) (<https://www.humanrestorationproject.org/>), v1.4

Neurodivergent Play Counts as Play

A child who is not playing the way the yard expects is still playing, and is often the first to lose the time.

All children have the capacity for play including those who are neurodivergent. They may line things up, have a deep love of the outdoors, collecting things or engaging in repetitive rhythms. It might not always make sense to us straight away but diversity within play is to be expected.

— Murphy, K. (2023), A guide to neurodiversity in the early years (www.annafreud.org/resources/...), Anna Freud Centre

Walking the perimeter alone is recess. Lining things up is recess. Stimming (<https://stimpunks.org/glossary/stimming/>) is recess. A child does not have to join the game to be getting what the break is for.

What to Ask For in the Room

- **Ask for it in writing that recess is never withheld.** Not "rarely", not "only when necessary". A policy with an exception is a policy that will be used.
 - **Ask what the removal is meant to achieve**, and how anyone would know whether it worked. Withheld recess is usually measured by whether the adult felt it was fair, not by whether the child's afternoon improved.
 - **Ask for unfinished work to be handled another way.** Work not finished is information about the task, the support, or the pace (<https://stimpunks.org/why/developmental-pace/>) — not a debt to be paid in break time.
 - **Ask what happens instead when a child is dysregulated.** If the answer involves sitting still somewhere quiet under supervision, that is the same intervention with a kinder name.
 - **Ask for the numbers.** How many minutes, for which children, how often withheld, broken down. The disparity does not show up until somebody counts.
 - **Ask that Neurodivergent play be counted as play** — including solitary, repetitive, or parallel play, and including a child who stays at the edge.
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What This Sheet Is Not

- **Not an argument that nothing should ever change after an incident.** It is an argument that the change should not be the removal of regulation.
 - **Not a claim that recess fixes everything.** It is a claim that removing it reliably makes things worse, which is a much smaller claim and much easier to act on.
 - **Not an attack on teachers.** Most withheld recess happens inside a policy, a timetable, and a testing regime that a teacher did not design and cannot personally repeal.
 - **Not only about behaviour.** Recess is cut in bulk, for test preparation, from the schools serving the children with the least. That is the larger theft.
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The Principle

A child who cannot get through the afternoon without moving is not disqualified from moving. They are telling you what the afternoon requires.

Recess is not what a child earns for being easy. It is part of what makes a child able.

Further Reading

- [Play](https://stimpunks.org/glossary/play/) (<https://stimpunks.org/glossary/play/>) — our glossary entry, with the fuller argument and its sources
 - [A Playground Should Have A Pulse](https://www.humanrestorationproject.org/writing/a-playground-should-have-a-pulse/) (<https://www.humanrestorationproject.org/writing/a-playground-should-have-a-pulse/>) · [Play's Power](https://writing.humanrestorationproject.org/plays-power/) (<https://writing.humanrestorationproject.org/plays-power/>) — Human Restoration Project
 - [Recess Is Not a Privilege](https://www.huffpost.com/entry/recess-is-not-a-privilege_b_8505720) (https://www.huffpost.com/entry/recess-is-not-a-privilege_b_8505720) — Laura Hanby Hudgens
 - Anthony D. Pellegrini, *The Recess Debate: A Disjuncture between Educational Policy and Scientific Research*, *American Journal of Play* 1, no. 2 (2008) — the primary source, in raw/
 - [Is Recess Important for Kids? Here's What the Research Says](https://time.com/4982061/recess-benefit-s-research-debate/) (<https://time.com/4982061/recess-benefit-s-research-debate/>) — *TIME*
 - [White kids usually get the most recess in Seattle. Black kids, the least](http://www.kuow.org/stories/...) (www.kuow.org/stories/...) — KUOW
 - [Recess in Seattle: How We Won the Right to Play](https://progressive.org/public-schools-advocate/recess-seattle-won-right-play/) (<https://progressive.org/public-schools-advocate/recess-seattle-won-right-play/>) — Jesse Hagopian
 - [Behaviorism](https://stimpunks.org/why/behaviorism/) (<https://stimpunks.org/why/behaviorism/>) — why a model that watches only compliance cannot see a child who needs to move
 - [Developmental Pace](https://stimpunks.org/why/developmental-pace/) (<https://stimpunks.org/why/developmental-pace/>) — on unfinished work as information rather than debt
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This sheet is also published as a page on stimpunks.org.

There is a [one-sheet broadside](#) of this argument — the version you pin up.